Gott says, we do not live in first or last times. So if your species is very young, it follows that it's unlikely to last long—because if it *were* to last long, you (and the rest of us alive today) *would* be extraordinary in living, proportionally speaking, so near the beginning.

What then is the projected longevity of our species? Gott concludes, at the 97.5 percent confidence level, that there will be humans for no more than 8 million years. That's his upper limit, about the same as the average lifetime of many mammalian species. In that case, our technology neither harms nor helps. But Gott's lower limit, with the same claimed reliability, is only 12 years. He will not give you 40-to-1 odds that humans will still be around by the time babies now alive become teenagers. In everyday life we try very hard not to take risks so large, not to board airplanes, say, with 1 chance in 40 of crashing. We will agree to surgery in which 95 percent of patients survive only if our disease has a greater than 5 percent chance of killing us. Mere 40-to-l odds on our species surviving another 12 years would be, if valid, a cause for supreme concern. If Gott is right, not only may we never be out among the stars; there's a fair chance we may not be around long enough even to make the first footfall on another planet.

To me, this argument has a strange, vaporish quality. Knowing nothing about our species except how old it is, we make numerical estimates, claimed to be highly reliable, about its future prospects. How? We go with the winners. Those who have been around are likely to stay around. Newcomers tend to disappear. The only assumption is the quite plausible one that there is nothing special about the moment at which we inquire into the matter. So why is the argument unsatisfying? Is it just that we are appalled by its implications?

Something like the Principle of Mediocrity must have very broad applicability. But we are not so ignorant as to imagine that everything is mediocre. There *is* something special about our time—not just the temporal chauvinism that those who reside in any epoch doubtless feel, but something, as outlined above, clearly unique and strictly relevant to our species' future chances: This is the first time